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Frequent Flyers
Non-Emergency Calls
Strain 911 System

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FROM ANKARA, WITH LOVE

The Battle for Turkey Reaches Texas Charter Schools



PHOTO COURTESY OF **MARK HALL**

BY **RAHUL NAGVEKAR**

Along a half-mile stretch of cleared trees between a veterinary hospital and a mortuary in Sugar Land, Texas, a Houston suburb, a new middle school is being built. When Harmony School of Excellence-Sugar Land opens this August, it will be funded by the state but, as a charter school, privately operated by a nonprofit. And it will be caught in a power struggle between Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan and his nemesis, Pennsylvania preacher Fethullah Gülen.

To some, Gülen is an inspiration; to others, he is a terrorist.

The middle school will be the newest addition to Harmony Public Schools, which, with 54 campuses, 3,800 staff, 33,500 students, and more than 258 million dollars in annual revenue from state and local funding, is Texas's largest charter network. It is also part of a group of about 170 American charter schools, spread across 26 states and the District of Columbia, founded and still operated by Turkish immigrants who rank among Gülen's millions of followers.

"STUDYING PHYSICS, MATHEMATICS, A

Robert Amsterdam is a high-flying London-based Canadian lawyer who thinks Gülen-linked charters in the U.S. exist first and foremost to funnel tax dollars to the cleric's global movement, Hizmet ("Service").

Last year, Amsterdam's firm published a 647-page book, *Empire of Deceit*, that lays out allegations of grievous wrongdoings by the schools. "Misuse of taxpayer funds totaling at least 243 million dollars," read emails the firm sent various state attorneys general this January. "More than 6,504 H-1B visas to import unqualified Turkish teachers. Widespread manipulation of state-mandated testing, grades, and attendance figures." (Harmony and its counterparts in other states have denied all of these claims.)

Amsterdam, whose firm has been hired by Erdoğan's government, has set out to convince states to take action against the schools and Hizmet. "It is a cult that have [*sic*] made a massive investment in U.S. politicians," Amsterdam told *The Politic* in an email.

Formally, Hizmet operates in the U.S. through various nonprofits, most of which are organized under the umbrella of the New York-based Alliance for Shared Values. Yuksel Alp Aslandoğan, the Alliance's executive director, is also Gülen's aide and translator.

"Our local affiliates—we have six of them—they focus on intercultural, interfaith, interideological dialogue [and] cultural activities," Aslandoğan told *The Politic*. For some affiliates, such as Houston's Dialogue Institute of the Southwest, that mission has included paying for politicians to visit Turkey on educational trips.

Schools like Harmony are not part of the Alliance. "[These schools] were established by Hizmet sympathizers," Aslandoğan acknowledged, although they regularly deny institutional links to Gülen's movement.

Harmony's Board of Directors maintains that the charters were established to help American kids learn science and math. Comparable to statistics for Texas's traditional public school system, half of Harmony's students are Hispanic, another fifth are black, and 61 percent qualify for free or reduced-price meals, according to Texas Education Agency (TEA) data.

Year after year, the network reports a 100 percent college acceptance rate.

"They push the kids to succeed and provide them with the kind of support that they need," William Martin, a professor emeritus of religion and public policy at Houston's Rice University, told *The Politic* in an interview.

Martin's opinion is fairly common, particularly among Texas politicians. In 2017, the state's charter school association named Soner Tarim, Harmony's then CEO, its Leader of the Year. Harmony was also one of three finalists nationwide for last year's Broad Prize, which annually "honors the public charter management organization that has demonstrated the best academic outcomes, particularly for low-income students and students of color."

After 18 years of rapid growth, the network's campuses now appear from El Paso to Beaumont, though most are located in the Houston, Austin, or Dallas-Fort Worth areas. Some are K-12 academies; others resemble traditional elementary, middle, or high schools. Some occupy drab buildings in industrial parks; others are giant multi-story structures that Harmony admits were built at costs approaching ten million dollars apiece. All fill their seats by lottery, and collectively, they report a waitlist 30,000 names long. None charge tuition.

Gülen, who began preaching in Turkey in the late 1960s, is revered by his followers as one of the Muslim world's foremost intellectuals and a tireless proponent of dialogue, tolerance, and selflessness.

"That people are talking with each other, guns are not talking. That is one idea—one core idea," Aslandoğan told *The Politic* as he described Gülen's philosophy.

Gülen also has a long history with education. "Studying physics, mathematics, and chemistry is worshipping God," he likes to say, according to *The Washington Post*. His followers were known for decades in Turkey for running highly successful cram schools that prepared students for university entrance examinations.

But Joshua Hendrick, a sociologist at Loyola University Maryland who has spent over a decade studying Hizmet, told *The Politic* that the tutoring centers served a strategic purpose.

"The objective of the organization in the '70s was to cultivate an elite cadre—what was referred to by Gülen himself as a 'golden generation'—that could, in a vanguard sort of way, lead

ND CHEMISTRY

the masses out of the darkness into the light," Hendrick said.

University degrees in hand, Gülen's supporters could ascend to the highest levels of influence in Turkish society over time. By the late 2000s, they had built a media empire that included the country's most widely read newspaper, *Zaman*, and multiple television stations. Hizmet sympathizers also held key positions in the military, police, and judiciary; ran Bank Asya and Istanbul's Fatih University; and operated at least a half dozen hospitals and hundreds of fully-fledged private schools, most of which were in Turkey.

Rice professor William Martin visited some of them on a Hizmet-sponsored trip in 2006. He makes no secret of his "warm feelings" toward the movement.

"We met some students who were very impressive kids," he told *The Politic*.

But over the past three decades, wealthy Gülen-supporting businessmen also founded Hizmet schools abroad, winning the movement admirers from Argentina to the Philippines.

Today, according to lists compiled by Gülen's opponents, schools established by Hizmet sympathizers can be found in at least 100 countries. But only in the U.S. are they funded with public money.

But around 2013, their relationship soured.

"The authoritarian tendencies

In Turkey, the cleric Gülen and the Islamic conservative politician Erdoğan were once allies. For a decade, they used Hizmet sympathizers in Turkey's courts to target their common secularist enemies, often in trials with doctored evidence.

were probably in [Erdoğan] all along... but he found the opportunity," the pro-Gülen Aslandoğan told *The Politic*.

Erdoğan accused Gülen of directing an extralegal parallel state, closed Hizmet cram schools, and converted the Turkish newspaper, *Zaman*, into a pro-government mouthpiece.

On the night of July 15, 2016, while Erdoğan was on vacation, a faction of the Turkish military tried to take government buildings and key infrastructure by force. When, within hours, the president regained control, he knew exactly who he wanted to blame.

"They were receiving their instructions from Pennsylvania," Erdoğan said of the coup plotters, claiming one of them had called the U.S.-based Gülen their leader. Gülen himself condemned the attempted coup and even suggested it may have been staged.

Hendrick, a fairly impartial observer, told *The Politic*, "There's some truth to both scenarios, of some culpability with the Gülen movement...and some efforts to take advantage of these events by Erdoğan and his regime to stamp out all forms of dissent."

Within weeks, more than 80,000 soldiers, judges, doctors, teachers, and other civil servants lost their jobs for links to Gülen—some for connections as minor as holding accounts at Hizmet-associated banks. The purges are ongoing, now primarily targeting other Erdoğan opponents like leftists and Kurds. By presidential decree, every Hizmet school and pro-Gülen media outlet in Turkey has been shuttered.

"About 50,000 Hizmet sympathizers are in jail, including around 4,000 women and 600 or so children

IS WORSHIPPING GOD."

"IF YOU ARE AGAINST

together with their mothers," Aslandoğan told *The Politic*.

"Without an exception, all of the Hizmet-associated institutions have been shut down by Erdoğan, including 35 hospitals, 15 universities, and 500 K-12 schools," he said.

Erdoğan is also targeting schools linked to Hizmet—he calls it the Gülenist Terror Organization—in other countries. Morocco has closed its Hizmet schools, while Afghanistan and Ethiopia have turned theirs over to a foundation run by the Turkish government. Last month, Turkish intelligence services apprehended five Hizmet teachers and a doctor in Kosovo.

In the U.S., after over a year of ineffectual lobbying, Gülen's extradition remains the Turkish government's ultimate prize. But neither the Obama nor Trump administrations believed that Gülen directed the failed coup or that he would get a fair trial in Turkey. So Erdoğan might have to settle for a different target—the charter schools.

"I've seen no evidence that the schools are teaching Islam," Hall acknowledged when he spoke with *The Politic*, countering a claim commonly made by more conspiracy-prone Harmony opponents.

He might find some local support. Austin attorney and independent filmmaker Mark Hall, for example, produced the 2016 documentary, *Killing Ed*, which claims corruption, discrimination, and academic fraud are commonplace at Harmony and other Gülen-linked charters.

But the schools do place a strong emphasis on Turkish language and culture, Hall said. Some offer Turkish as their only foreign language, and many used to take students on trips to Turkey to participate in the Hizmet-sponsored International Turkish Language Olympiads.

"There's no document with Fethullah Gülen's signature on it that establishes a charter school in California or Texas or Ohio or wherever," Hall noted. "So a lot of people in the Gülen movement itself have said, 'We have no formal, legalistic connection between Harmony and Fethullah Gülen.' And that probably is not true."

Aslandoğan, the Alliance for Shared Values director, previously worked in Houston. When he spoke with *The Politic*, he described his involvement with Hizmet in Texas.

"Together with a group of friends we formed the Texas Gulf education center, which later grew to become North American University," he said. "So I was its first president."

As noted in a 2010 TEA report, Texas Gulf helped Harmony certify its teachers. And according to two separate interviews in *Killing Ed*, North American University plays a key role in maintaining Harmony's public image.

"They force the kids to apply to college, and then the North American [University] accepts them all," says "Linda," a former teacher at Harmony School of Innovation-Houston who appears anonymously in the film. "So they create their own 100 percent acceptance rate."

The Politic asked Aslandoğan what he made of allegations of wrongdoing against schools like Harmony with links to Gülen.

"It is of course possible that—being run by human beings—some teachers or administrators might have done some things that are unethical or inappropriate," Aslandoğan said. "And it is possible it might have reached a certain level. But so far, despite the decades of operation and multiple inquiries, not a single individual was charged with any crime."

In a case in 2008, a female Hispanic teacher at Harmony

DO ANYTHING TO DESTROY YOU."

T THEM, THEY WILL

Harmony and its counterparts across the country have, however, faced civil rights lawsuits from former employees alleging a particular pattern of discrimination.

Science Academy-El Paso claimed that her male coworkers of Turkish origin, despite being uncertified and struggling with English, were being paid over 50 percent more than she was, and that she lost her job for complaining. The principal she unsuccessfully sued, Fatih Ay, is now Harmony's CEO. (Ay and other members of Harmony's board corresponded with *The Politic* but did not agree to interviews.)

"There's been a lot of cases that have been settled," Hall said. "The Gülen movement does not like to have cases go beyond the early stages because, I think, they're fearful of discovery—at the ability to go and use the court system to look further into their operations."

Still, Hall and Amsterdam are convinced there is widespread preferential treatment for the schools' Turkish male employees.

"One of the Turkish male teachers who had worked there for only two years in the same pay grade as I was—he had left his paycheck on the copier machine, and it said that he had brought home that month 4,300 dollars," "Linda" recalls in *Killing Ed*.

"Meanwhile, I'm making about 1,000 dollars a paycheck. He was under the section that said you would be paid that much if you had been working there for 22 years," she says.

In 2016, Amsterdam's firm filed a TEA complaint against Harmony that references an anonymous 2011 review of Harmony Science Academy-Austin left on the website, Great Schools.

"It is sad and frustrating that there are only two qualifications to meet in order to advance as faculty," wrote a self-identified former employee. "One is to be male, the second is to be Turkish. Unfortunately, I did not meet the second qualification, so I spent all of my years working under Turkish first year teachers who were somehow made department chair."

Harmony responded to the complaint saying that only seven percent of its employees—mostly men from Turkey—were in the U.S. on H-1B visas to fill STEM teaching jobs for which qualified Americans could not be found. This is a common refrain among Gülen-linked schools in multiple states.

Texas State Representative Dan Flynn (R-Canton) is skeptical. "I heard that there was a carpenter that came here to teach American history. That bothered me a little bit," he told journalist and anti-Gülen activist Sibel Edmonds in an interview last December.

Hizmet-linked schools' strongest critics, including Amsterdam, believe the schools have little interest in finding qualified teachers and instead provide a convenient vehicle for mass immigration fraud.

Even the pro-Harmony Martin told *The Politic*, "They certainly have used the visas in a much more aggressive way than, I think it's fair to say, pretty much any other organization."

Mustafa Emanet, a former H-1B holder who worked as an IT administrator at the Hizmet-associated Horizon Science Academy Denison Middle School in Cleveland, Ohio between 2006 and 2009, would go a step further.

"Ninety-nine percent of [Turkish employees at Hizmet-associated schools in the U.S.] are in this movement," Emanet, who received his job at Horizon through a friend in Hizmet, told *The Politic* in an interview.

And when Emanet worked at Horizon, he said, he and other Turkish employees did not take home their full publicly-funded salaries. Instead, the school's business manager used Hizmet bylaws to determine their actual pay.

"He makes the calculation and tells you, 'You owe the organization [the difference],'" Emanet said, explaining that managers would collect tithes at regular meetings. "They are stealing U.S. taxpayers' money, I can say that."

Over his bosses' objections, Emanet married one of his American coworkers, Mary Addi, who convinced him to come forward about the alleged forced tithing—amounting to about 40 percent of his official salary, according to an interview he gave to *CBS This Morning* last March. He left the school and provided a copy of the bylaws—Horizon claims he forged it—to the FBI, which has since raided Gülen-linked charters in Ohio, Indiana, and Illinois.

The raids did not result in any arrests. "What was it, 2012, or '11, they did the FBI raids?" Addi said, exasperated. "I mean, I went on *60 Minutes* in 2012. Nothing has changed. Instead, their schools continue to grow."

But when Emanet visited Turkey in 2009, he was arrested (and eventually acquitted) on heroin trafficking charges. He is convinced he was framed by Gülen supporters in the Turkish police.

"Either you are with them or you are against them," Emanet told *The Politic*. "If you are against them, they will do anything to destroy you."

"The charter school lobby, which is very defensive of Harmony, is very strong in Texas," explained Liz Whyte, a journalist who has covered Robert Amsterdam's efforts for the Center for Public Integrity, in an interview with *The Politic*.

Amsterdam's firm's TEA complaint against Harmony

"THEY'VE GOT THE PERFECT, PERFECT FORMUL

Turkey is against them. Texas might not be.

from two years ago alleged not only discrimination and visa fraud but also misuse of taxpayer funds, including through favoritism for Gülen-linked companies when awarding tens of millions of dollars' worth of publicly-funded construction contracts.

In 2011, according to a change order document shown in *Killing Ed*, Harmony paid a contractor owned by a former employee 37,500 dollars for a "Dome change to resemble Texas Capitol" on its School of Political Science and Communication in Austin—but the finished building had no dome.

The TEA ruled that most of the violations listed in Amsterdam's complaint were outside of its jurisdiction and dismissed the favoritism claims, noting that the majority of Harmony's contracts between 2014 and 2016 were with non-Turkish-owned companies.

"Essentially, the TEA is a charter school lobbying arm," Amsterdam told *The Politic*. "They're not a regulator."

Flynn, one of Harmony's most vocal critics in the Texas Legislature, called on state Attorney General Ken Paxton's office to investigate the schools instead.

"Texans deserve better and they deserve to be protected from organizations that may be funneling funds to illegal foreign activity and terror," reads a constituent newsletter sent on July 25, 2016, ten days after the attempted coup in Turkey, that also claims Harmony overpaid a front group at least 18 million dollars in taxpayer money for leases on its buildings.

"You know, we're so worried about keeping people out of our country and building walls and everything," Addi remarked to *The Politic*. "Let's look internally at what's going on with publicly-funded schools run by an alleged terrorist organization."

Paxton did not open an investigation. (Both his office and the TEA declined to comment for this story.) This January, Amsterdam's firm requested to meet with him; so far, he has not responded.

"If the attorney general's not looking at it, he's either got a good legal reason not to look at it or he's got a good political reason not to look at it," said Scott Milder, who unsuccessfully challenged Texas's incumbent and strongly pro-charter Lieutenant Governor Dan Patrick in March's Republican primary, in an interview with *The Politic*.

Milder acknowledged he was not familiar with all of the allegations against Harmony and Hizmet, but he centered his campaign on attacking Patrick's support for redirecting public school funds toward charters and voucher programs. While Milder does not oppose charters, he believes they need more oversight. "Public schools are an open book," he said. "Who are the donors [affiliated with] the charter schools? Who is Gülen donating to in our Texas Legislature?"

Last year, an investigation by Whyte found that ten Texas state lawmakers, along with 141 of their colleagues from other states, took trips to Turkey between 2006 and 2015 that were funded in part by Hizmet nonprofits like Houston's Raindrop Turkish House and the Dialogue Institute.

"I think the number is probably much more. Those were just the ones we could confirm," Whyte told *The Politic*. Similar trips, thousands in total nationwide, were offered to members of Congress, mayors, law enforcement officials, and academics like Martin.

"Anyone that could speak well of the movement publicly was generally someone that nonprofits invited," Whyte said.

In January 2011, the Texas Senate adopted a resolution to "commend Fethullah Gülen for his dedication to working toward a better world through education, service, tolerance, and the free exchange of ideas and extend to him best wishes for continued success." At least three of its five cosponsors—two Democrats and a Republican—had taken Hizmet trips.

The following year, State Representative Alma Allen (D-Houston) was confronted by a right-wing activist concerned about foreigners teaching at Harmony's schools. "I think they are fabulous," Allen responded. "Because they are from Turkey, wonderful Turkey. I've been there twice. It's beautiful. You should go. You want to go? I'll take you."

The sponsored trips were never illegal, but they have now stopped due to Erdoğan's crackdown on Hizmet.

"Now that they've lost power in Turkey and a great amount of their revenue, they're trying to further expand the schools in the United States," Addi told *The Politic*. "Because they've got the perfect, perfect formula here for pillaging our tax funds."

She continued, "And how they've been allowed to get away with it? I have no clue—well, actually, I do. They pay off the politicians, who

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readily accept their campaign contributions and look the other way."

But in the 2017 session of the usually charter-friendly Texas Legislature, State Representative James White (R-Hillister) introduced a bill that would have effectively banned non-U.S. citizens from serving on the governing boards of most Texas charter schools.

The bill, which stalled in committee, did not mention Harmony specifically. But in an interview with *The Politic*, White indicated that he knew of allegations that many of the network's schools are controlled by Turkish nationals in Hizmet. "I think if Harmony wants to get away from these allegations," White said, "they should have supported my bill."

Still, White was unfamiliar with Amsterdam's lobbying campaign. "I haven't dealt with anyone on investigating Harmony," he said.

Amsterdam's point person in Texas is Jim Arnold, an Austin-based former Republican operative who is now registered as a foreign agent working for Turkey's government. In an email to *The Politic*, Flynn admitted meeting with Amsterdam's firm but denied coordinating with the firm's anti-Harmony efforts. Instead, he maintained he was focused on concerns about the schools he had heard from Texas voters.

"People want to know something is being done and Harmony is being made to be subject to the same transparency standards as public schools," Flynn wrote.

If legislative efforts will be stymied by the charter lobby, Amsterdam's other option is law enforcement. There, he will face a distinct challenge: proving beyond doubt that organic connections between the schools and Gülen exist.

"The organizational model allows for a mechanism of plausible deniability that is intentional," Loyola's Hendrick told *The Politic*, explaining that no one would ever find a paper trail linking Gülen to any American charter school or, for that matter, to any Hizmet-associated company.

Hendrick said the tactic was perfected in late-20th century Turkey, when that country was controlled by secularists and association with a religious figure like Gülen was a liability. Now, the same defense mechanism has proven useful against a different enemy.

"Something that bedevils the Turkish government right now [is that] when it comes to the Gülen community, all evidence that can be gathered about anything they do, whether it's these various alleged nefarious activities or any other positive activities they do—it's very difficult to find a direct connection," Hendrick said.

None of that may matter to the sixth, seventh, and eighth graders who enroll at Harmony School of Excellence-Sugar Land in the fall. But for a president and a preacher, a London lawyer and a Texas filmmaker, the students will become the latest characters in a battle for the future of Turkey.

"It is a conspiracy," Mark Hall said at a lightly attended anti-Gülen protest in Austin last December. "But it's a conspiracy of facts."

TAX FUNDS."

PILLAGING OUR

Farmers, Fields, and Fear

The Colombian Growers Caught in the War on Coca

BY **VERÓNICA LIRA ORTIZ**

"Quien no quiera cultivar, que se vaya o lo matamos."
Anyone who doesn't want to grow can either leave or be killed.

A YOUNG MAN with a hard look on his face and a weapon by his side said this to a group of farmers in Nariño, a department in western Colombia, according to a source who witnessed the interaction.

The source, who works for a Colombian non-governmental organization, said the young man was part of a criminal group that produces and sells cocaine, both inside and outside of Colombia. Government officials had just visited Nariño, offering money and seeds to farmers on the condition that they would agree to eliminate their crops of coca—their main source of income.

While cocaine attracts attention from U.S. media and politicians, the raw material used to make the drug—the coca plant—often goes unmentioned in public discourse. But coca is the primary source of income for thousands of families in rural Colombia, and its cultivation has complicated bilateral relations between Colombia and the U.S.

In the summer of 2016, the Nariño farmers faced a difficult choice. They could leave their hometown to avoid being killed by drug traffickers for refusing to grow coca, or they could reject the government's offer and continue to grow the illicit coca crop in defiance of the authorities.

Growing coca is a dangerous business. Government airplanes deploy bombs to wipe out cartels, posing a serious risk to farmers living in the area. Cartels hide landmines in fields to kill soldiers sent by the government to eradicate the coca plants, endangering farmers' lives, too.

Cocaine drives a vast transnational drug industry. High demand in the U.S. incentivizes cartels to continue their operations, and poor regulation of entry channels enables the transport of cocaine into the country.

The U.S. and Colombia's joint efforts to counter cocaine produc-

"Anyone who doesn't want to grow can either leave or be killed."

tion place a particular burden on the Colombian people. Drug cartels and former *guerrilleros*, civilians engaged in guerilla warfare, control coca production in Colombia. While the Colombian government is more concerned with disrupting criminal groups than with punishing coca growers, cartels provide farmers with financial support, which makes it difficult for the government to target cartels without harming coca growers.

Despite the Colombian government's efforts, coca farmers have not been deterred from growing their crop. According to a 2016 report by the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, coca production increased by about 52 percent in 2016, from 237,000 to 360,000 acres of crop. The growth was concentrated in the departments of Nariño, Putumayo, and Santander. More than 85,000 families in Colombia earn their income by cultivating coca. A 2017 United Nations report estimated that each farmer was paid, on average, 1,200 dollars per year by cartels and other criminal groups for growing the crop illegally.

In 2016, Colombia signed a peace agreement with the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (FARC), a Marxist-Leninist guerrilla group, in an attempt to end the Colombian conflict, a half-century-long war between the Colombian government and paramilitary and guerrilla groups. The government hopes the agreement will establish peace, in addition to striking a blow to the nation's cocaine industry. The agreement also includes a provision for compensating farmers who switch from coca cultivation to the production of other crops.

But coca eradication efforts have had unintended consequences. As FARC disbands its cocaine operations, other groups are stepping in to fill the void. At the same time, farmers across the country are rushing to plant coca so that they will be rewarded financially when they switch back to the crops they had grown before. Cocaine prices have dropped dramatically as the coca supply has surged.

Now, coca farmers are navigating uncertain terrain. They stand to benefit from cooperation with the government's plan, but they must also negotiate with a new breed of criminal groups that have surfaced in the wake of FARC's demilitarization.

THE U.S. GOVERNMENT considers drug trafficking a matter of American national security. In an interview with *The Politic*, Juan Carlos Garzón Vergara, a global fellow at the Woodrow Wilson Center in Washington, D.C. and a research associate at Fundación Ideas para la Paz (Foundation of Ideas for Peace) in Colombia, said, "Given the United States' perception of narco-trafficking, they have a dual agenda. First, to weaken guerrilla groups it became necessary to strike the narco[tics industry]. Second, the armed conflict surrounding the drug industry has reached the point at which it is considered terrorism."

In 2000, the U.S. began the Plan Colombia initiative to fight drug cartels and insurgents in Colombia. But government officials in both the U.S. and Colombia have admitted publicly that their efforts have been insufficient. In 2017, President Trump publicly criticized Colombia's eradication policies. He accused Colombia as being guilty of the surge of cocaine consumption in the U.S., and stated that the South American country had done very little to mitigate the problem, in spite of the "large" amount of resources the U.S. had provided to tackle drug trafficking and organized crime.

"When the grand [drug] organizations and cartels leave the local market, new groups start to take advantage of local communities and enhance the local production," Hernando Zuleta, the director of the

"It is impossible for them to stop growing these crops unless there are real opportunities for generating income."

Centre for Studies on Security and Drugs at the University of the Andes in Bogotá, explained in an interview with *The Politic*. "There is not permanent success in the fight against drugs."

WHILE COCA CROPS are eradicated through either forced or voluntary elimination, rural farmers in Colombia live in constant fear that armed forces will enter their lands in order to eliminate the crops. The strategy of forced elimination previously involved aerial spraying of glyphosate, an herbicide, in addition to manual extraction by the military. In 2015, however, the use of glyphosate was prohibited because of its high levels of toxicity, forcing the Colombian government to rely on exclusively on armed forces who would manually extract the crops. Voluntary elimination is also known as "illicit crop substitution." The strategy allows farmers to continue using their lands only if they destroy their coca-crops and replace them with cacao, corn, sugar, or other legal crops.

But Garzón explained that there isn't "one grand strategy for eradication."

"Drug policies have to be thought about according to a specific context," he said. "In the short term, forced eradication seems to work better. But if the strategy is not accompanied by government actions to continue monitoring areas of potential growth, then not only will it fail, but [it will] also provoke a high rate of re-sowing."

Putumayo, next to Colombia's border with Ecuador, is one of the main coca-producing regions in the country. Last year, the Colombian government, FARC, and local agriculture organizations began a joint project in Putumayo to substitute coca crops in at least 40 municipalities with cacao, corn, or coffee. But, according to the aforementioned source working for the Colombian NGO, farmers in Putumayo fear for their livelihoods.

"Coca crops have been a source of stable income for many families. It is impossible for them to stop growing these crops unless there are real opportunities for generating income," Zuleta said.

Without better roads and infrastructure, the areas where farmers grow coca crops will remain largely inaccessible to outsiders, and the strategy of crop substitution will fail, said Daniel Cardona, a lawyer and researcher for Del Rosario University in Bogotá, in an interview with *The Politic*.

"Crop-substitution worked in Montes de María because it's an area surrounded by economic centers, which gave local communities the opportunity to diversify their economy and streamline processes," Cardona noted—but the strategy won't work everywhere. In some of the most rural areas, changes in development policies—not only in drug policies—are overdue.

ON MAY 27, Colombia will hold presidential elections. The candidates have very different proposals for the eradication of coca crops, though they agree on the ultimate goal. Iván Duque, the candidate for the conservative party, Centro Democrático, wants to return to glyphosate air spraying. Leading in the polls, he believes that glyphosate techniques are integral to reducing the cultivation of illicit crops.

In contrast, Sergio Fajardo of the green Alianza Verde party forcefully opposes the use of glyphosate. Instead, he believes in enhancing crop substitution programs, providing goods to rural communities, and increasing opportunities for young people.

Humberto de la Calle, of Partido Liberal Colombiano, believes that glyphosate should only be used as a last resort, given the harm it causes to the environment and to human health. For De la Calle, efforts to eradicate illicit drug trafficking should focus on seizing traffickers' goods and implementing policies that prevent farmers from turning to coca cultivation for income.

The future of Colombia's anti-coca campaign is uncertain. The fight against drug production and consumption continues, but the choice of a strategy to tackle these problems will depend on the upcoming election and the majority in Congress.

"I don't know what happened to the Nariño farmers," the source at the NGO told me. "I never went back. They were afraid of losing everything and starting from scratch, but they were more afraid of getting killed or being followed in case they ran away."

"They were afraid of losing everything and starting from scratch, but they were more afraid of getting killed or being followed in case they ran away."

A New Haven Organization Empowers Addicts After Prison



BY **AYLA KHAN**

RE-THINKING RECOVERY

THE FIRST CALL CAME IN at 2:37 p.m. on January 25, 2018. A woman had fallen to the ground on Court Street, and she died soon after, the *New Haven Independent* reported. Two more calls followed in the next fifteen minutes. Within the hour, paramedics rushed five people to the emergency room at Yale New Haven Hospital. The patients had all smoked K2, a synthetic drug.

K2 is one of many drugs responsible for skyrocketing overdoses in Connecticut. The Office of the Chief Medical Examiner reported that 917 people died due to accidental "drug intoxication deaths" in 2016—more

than double the 357 who died in 2012. With high drug use comes questions about how the state should respond.

Approaches tend to fall into two camps: incarceration and rehabilitation. But in New Haven, a recovery house seeks to improve on existing options and provide more holistic services than standard rehabilitation centers. Believe In Me Empowerment Corporation (BIMEC), which caters to formerly incarcerated people in general, is one safe haven for recovering addicts in Connecticut. Most BIMEC clients were formerly incarcerated for drug abuse and receive counseling, housing services, employment training, and case management services through the organization.

On March 26, 2018, I visited the BIMEC recovery house, located in New Haven's Dixwell neighborhood. When I arrived, I met James Walker, the organization's executive director. He led me to a small conference room, where I observed a weekly meeting and spoke with several attendees.

Vanessa, a formerly incarcerated woman with loose red curls, told me about her struggle with addiction.

"I am an ex-crack cocaine and heroin addict," Vanessa said. She called her time in prison "horrible."

"For one, it's a terrible culture shock," she said. "The correction officers are jerks, rude, and belligerent." She added, "The food is slop. If you don't have money for commerce, you could be starving for days."

Still, Vanessa said her arrest and imprisonment were an important wake-up call.

"If I wasn't incarcerated, I'm positive I'd have been dead by now," she told me. Even so, Vanessa does not credit prison with helping her overcome her addiction. She explained that she was motivated to quit drugs for her family's benefit. "It was all for my son," she said.

MOST PEOPLE INCARCERATED on drug-related charges continue to experience addiction problems after they leave prison. Ninety-five percent return to substance abuse, and 60 to 80 percent commit new crimes, according to the National Association of Drug Court Professionals.

For former inmates, BIMEC and similarly structured recovery homes, like A New Beginning Recovery Houses, Harrison House, and Step Up Inn, aid in the reentry process. BIMEC provides a space for its clients to focus on recovery while

"After that, you just use them to numb the pain of life."

"If I wasn't incarcerated, I'm positive I'd have been dead by now."

"Make [these programs] known to people—they change lives."

remaining sober, working, and doing community service.

Not all rehabilitation centers take BIMEC's approach. While BIMEC aims to provide a holistic set of services, standard drug rehabilitation centers focus specifically on providing addiction treatment. The overarching aim of drug rehabilitation centers is to create an environment for addicts to recover both physically and psychologically.

But these centers do not always account for their vast array of needs. Without addressing the underlying causes of addiction—such as unemployment or inadequate access to mental health care—the centers can fail to fully rehabilitate their patients and set them up for success after their departure. Several BIMEC attendees said that before visiting a recovery home, they went to rehabilitation centers, where they had greater difficulty overcoming their addiction.

Wayne, another attendee, also considered checking himself into rehab but did not take steps to do so—until one day, he decided "he didn't want dirt in his body anymore."

Wayne visited three different rehabilitation facilities: the Stonington Institute, Rushford, and Grant Street Partnership. The basic routine at rehab, Wayne explained, involved "breakfast, morning meditation, lunch, group meetings, sports, and dinner." At the last facility he stayed at, which had a strict no-tolerance policy, Wayne was caught using drugs. Wayne said he was "kicked out onto the streets."

In some cases, attendees who leave a rehabilitation center sober do not receive continued support post-departure.

"Once you're out, you're out," Wayne said, shrugging. Some facilities are also underfunded and understaffed, which means that drugs can move "in and out of the place," Wayne said.

Recovery homes attempt to address the constellation of challenges faced by formerly incarcerated drug addicts. Repeat felony offenders often struggle to apply for education grants, find jobs, and access social and vocational training. Recovery homes can help the formerly incarcerated find employment and avoid turning to drug-related crime.

At BIMEC, staff members help attendees create resumes and search for jobs. Employment can provide recovering addicts with a sense of responsibility and normalcy. A study conducted by *Social Science & Medicine* in 2012 found that "people holding down full time employment enjoyed the most physical activity and reported the lowest levels of alcohol consumption and cigarette smoking."

Wayne and Vanessa both believe that recovery homes play a crucial role in ensuring that recovery is long-lasting.

"Make [these programs] known to people—they change lives," Vanessa said.

Wayne, who is employed as BIMEC's house manager, told me he appreciates BIMEC's services and gets along well with his therapist. "I'm doing awesome!" he said.

Still, Vanessa feels the effects of stigma as she rebuilds her life. "New Haven shuns and looks down on addicts," she said. "On leaving prison, I found that my two best friends died because of cocaine overdoses. Nobody cared. Their names weren't even mentioned in the papers."

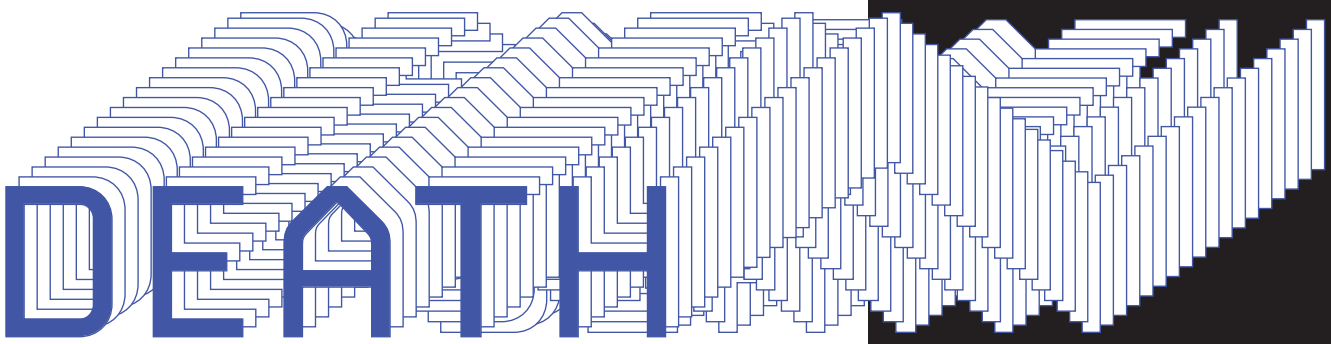
"People wrongly think drug abuse is a choice," Wayne told me. He flagged the decision to try drugs as a critical turning point. "After that," he said, "you just use them to numb the pain of life."

At the end of my visit, Wayne flashed a toothy smile at me. He has begun to build his resume as manager at BIMEC, opening up opportunities for the future. On my way out, I saw a flash of red on his worn-out shirt—a badge that read, "Employee."

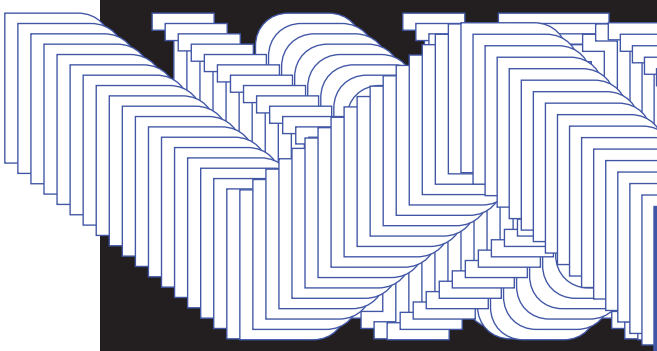
e-mortality

BY TC MARTIN

Michele Flanigan doesn't sound li
necromancer on the phone. She lau
easily, and many of her sentences
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Before she took her current job as office manager at Lakeview Cemetery in Bridgeport, Connecticut, where her grandmother and mother also worked, Flanigan did a stint in New Haven at Grove Street Cemetery, Yale's silent neighbor. When she started, the burial records were "a mess," she told me. She immediately began to organize the records with Microsoft Excel for quicker reference.

"I have to [organize the records], because otherwise I may never find what I'm looking for," she said. "I'm an organizational freak, so that was definitely my first priority."

What started out as a managerial project soon morphed into an attempt to digitize death. Over the next two years, the Grove Street staff uploaded the records Flanigan digitized to a searchable database on the cemetery's website. Flanigan was struck by how many families called the office asking for their loved ones' records to be added to the database. Thousands of the burials on the site—8,023 of the more than 14,000 listed—occurred before 1990, when the Internet began to go mainstream. For many of them, other than their archived obituaries, these online burial records are the only digital evidence of their existence.

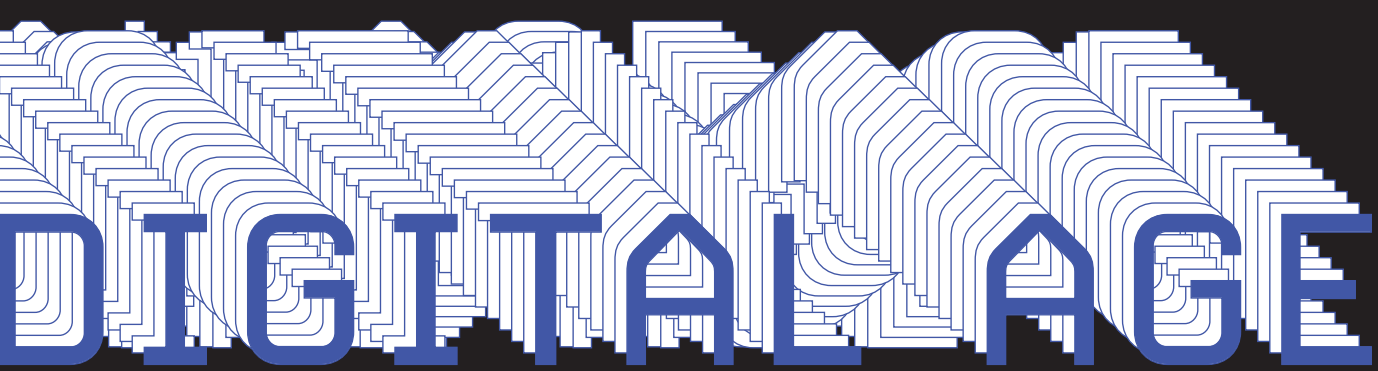
When Flanigan set out to reorganize her workspace, she inadvertently resurrected more than 8,000 people in cyberspace. But Flanigan's project is not unique, nor is it the most ambitious: a quick Google search for "digital death" reveals countless websites and services that aim to protect our online legacies after we pass on. From creating simple memorial websites to designing complex social networks, arranging for an afterlife in the cloud could soon become a normal part of preparing for death, not unlike finalizing a will or selecting a casket.

FIVE YEARS AGO, MANDY Benoualid and her father paid a visit to a large cemetery near downtown Montreal. Benoualid's grandmother was interred in the cemetery's columbarium, a stone structure that holds funeral urns. When she passed away, the urn containing her ashes had been placed in one of the many compartments lining the columbarium's wall. Benoualid was paying her respects to her beloved grandmother when a glimmer caught her eye.

A CD cased in plastic rested in front of an urn with a man's name inscribed on it. The front of the case said, "Dad's work."

Presuming "Dad" to be a writer or a musician, Benoualid googled the name on the urn but could not find any information about his life. He had no digital presence. She was frustrated by the elusiveness of his identity.

"Everybody in a cemetery has some type of history, some type



It's probably not

FOREVER

but it's something.

"There's that date of birth and that date of death and that dash in between, and there's so much life story within that dash."

of story to tell," Benoualid told me. "There's that date of birth and that date of death and that dash in between, and there's so much life story within that dash."

Shortly after that cemetery visit, she set out to help people define their dashes.

In 2013, Benoualid founded Qeepr, a website whose mission is "to ensure a loved one's legacy lives on(line) forever." A deceased person's relatives can use Qeepr to design a custom online memorial page complete with photos, life milestones, and a family tree. Qeepr is one member of a larger suite of websites working to answer the same question: what should happen to our digital presence when we die?

Qeepr's answer is simple: digital death, like digital life, should be social.

Every Qeepr page displays a profile picture of the deceased and a banner image, much like a Twitter account. The biography section lists important information about the person's family, resting place, and life milestones. The mementos section holds photos and videos, while the family and relations sections provide more details about the person's relatives.

Benoualid gave me the link to a mock profile so I could explore Qeepr's functionalities. The fictional deceased person is a woman named Caroline. According to her biography, Caroline passed away three years ago. When I first log onto her page, I am surprised by how interactive it is.

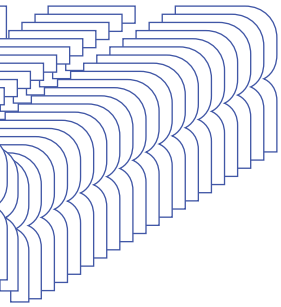
"We actually built the site initially on the main principles of social media," Benoualid said.

I browse Caroline's page. There are about a half-dozen mementos of her life posted, all of them photographs. I can see the users she is related to, including her daughter, her mother, and even her step-grandmother. I discover that the account is managed jointly by her daughter and the cemetery where Caroline is supposedly buried. A map of New Mexico shows me exactly where I could have found her grave if she were real, even down to the plot number.

I spot a small comment section at the bottom of the profile. The most recent comment—the site dubs it a "condolence"—was posted last November. Four months before that, Caroline's husband posted a picture of their wedding, which, her milestone timeline tells me, took place more than fifty years ago. Anyone on Qeepr, even total strangers, could view Caroline's profile and post on her page. Caroline's family opted out of the invite-only privacy setting, making her profile accessible to the public.

For about seventy dollars, the family can purchase a half-dollar-sized plaque with a unique QR code printed on it. The code links directly to Caroline's memorial page, and the plaque can be placed near her headstone. Her life will be just a camera snap away.

WHEN MARC SANER, a professor at the University of Ottawa, isn't busy



directing the Institute for Science, Society, and Policy (ISSP)—a network of professors and students exploring topics in technology governance and innovation policy—he is pursuing his cherished hobby: his digital cemetery.

Saner is the president of the World Wide Cemetery (Cemetery.org), a memorial website created in 1995 by the engineer Michael Kibbee, who died of Hodgkin's lymphoma two years later. In 2014, Saner began directing the site, which allows users to create online memorial pages for their deceased loved ones. The pages are guaranteed to remain online and ad-free for a century. Digital real estate is still real estate, but it is considerably cheaper. The going rate for a page on the site is 90 dollars, less than one-tenth the price of a modest headstone.

The World Wide Cemetery is far less interactive than Qeepr.

"I was looking for something really simple and basic with no ads… something like a graveyard," Saner told me. "It is the exact opposite of what you would expect in 2018 from the Internet."

When I visit the site, the first thing I notice is the quiet, the stillness. There are no pop-ups, no flashing animations, and no advertisements: just an obituary in black text set against a beige background. Funeral home wallpaper comes to mind. I click on the memorial of the site's creator, Mike Kibbee. His warm smile greets me as I pull up the page: two photos of him have been included in the memorial. I have the option to leave a short message for free, or, for nine dollars, I can leave a longer message with virtual flowers. Saner personally monitors the postings to prevent disrespectful comments from desecrating the space—the digital version of perpetual care.

I click on a few other memorials, browsing them slowly and methodically, as I would the rows of fallen soldiers at Arlington. The lack of digital noise adds a touch of serenity to my web-surfing.

In the World Wide Cemetery, Saner has wedded the tranquility of a cemetery to the convenience of the web. In the process, he has created a time capsule containing not just photographs and memories, but life stories.

For the several hundred residents of Cemetery.org, their memorials may be the only lasting digital imprints of their lives.

"Not everyone is notable enough for a Wikipedia entry. If you're not notable, then you're just gone," Saner lamented.

Their pages will survive for at least the next three generations, meaning their great-grandchildren may well visit their website rather than their gravesite. It's probably not forever, but it's something.

EVEN WITHOUT QEEPR or the World Wide Cemetery, it's possible that our digital ghosts could continue to haunt the web after our deaths on social media.

What happens to our accounts—and who gains control over them—after we die is somewhat hazy. Many sites such as Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter allow the deceased's family to decide the account's fate. Twitter only offers the option of deactivation, but both Facebook and Instagram offer permanent deletion or memorialization. If an account is memorialized, people can still view it, and, in Facebook's case, family members can interact with other mourners through the account. However, who has the final say in creating the memorial is not clear, nor is the lifetime of the memorial page clearly defined.

In short, we probably should not rely on social media to faithfully preserve our digital legacies. Even if we could, I am not sure I would want my last words to be some random RuPaul's Drag Race meme I managed to retweet seconds before I croaked.

Sites like Qeepr and Cemetery.org seem to be our best shots at digital immortality for now. In sheer numbers, there is no comparison: the World Wide Cemetery has a few hundred online memorials, whereas Qeepr has almost one hundred thousand. Yet the concept is essentially the same: using the web to remember people who might otherwise be forgotten.

Perhaps one day, sites like these will bring us closer to virtual immortality in cyberspace. If that happens, the inscription on the imposing gates that guard Grove Street Cemetery might finally come true. "The dead shall be raised,"—or, at least, uploaded.

Frequent Flyers

Non-Emergency Calls Strain 911 System

BY **KAT LIN**

PARAMEDIC SUPERVISOR ALEX ROEHNER and I are in a fly car charging down the wrong side of Nepperhan Avenue in Yonkers, New York. Alex switches between her sirens as the SUV weaves through traffic and unconcerned pedestrians.

"Two phones, four radios, a laptop, and a partridge in a pear tree," she sighs as she fiddles with her two phones with her left hand and guides the steering wheel with her right.

Five foot ten, the 47-year-old has two studs in the left side of her nose, and a purple ribbon accents her handheld radio. (Her aura is red, she explains, but she likes purple because it's tranquil.) Her colleagues call Alex the mom of Empress Emergency Medical Services (EMS), but Alex describes herself on her social media and dating app profiles as a "gypsy medic," a reference to her Roma heritage.

Five years ago, Alex switched careers from "artist and drug addict," she tells me, to emergency medical service provider. Since then, Alex has risen from emergency medical technician (EMT) to paramedic lieutenant, or "road boss." She manages her team of paramedics and EMTs, reads patient care reports, approves Refusal of Medical Assistance requests, and drives an Empress SUV—a fly car—equipped with sirens, lights, and medical gear.

This Friday afternoon, in early November, we are headed to a nursing home in downtown Yonkers. Alex and her crew have been called to treat a "diff breather," which is EMS-speak for someone who is having difficulty breathing. Alex grabs her purple stethoscope from the

dashboard. An ambulance crew—a paramedic and an EMT—pulls into the parking lot.

The fly car is mobile and quick, allowing Alex to provide backup where needed, and, often, to get to the scene before an ambulance can. When the most critical moments of an emergency have passed and the crew has begun to transport the stabilized patients to the hospital, Alex is dispatched to the next emergency.

When we arrive at the nursing home, Alex grabs a heart monitor and another medical bag from the trunk and rushes into the building with a stretcher in tow. We keep moving as a nurse intercepts us in the hallway and tells us what she knows about the patient: he's in the room at the end of the hallway, on the left; his blood oxygenation level is 70 percent.

Time is critical. When blood oxygen saturation falls below 90 percent, the body starts to suffocate. Soon after the drop, skin changes color and confusion sets in as the brain struggles to maintain itself without oxygen. The lungs try to compensate for the lack of oxygen by breathing faster and shallower. Within a few minutes of the first symptoms, organs fail and begin to die.

When the paramedics find the diff breather, a 68-year-old man wearing a gray beanie, he is shivering in his bed. Alex approaches.

"What's wrong, baby?" she asks the man.

He glances at her without moving his head.

"The nurse doesn't know how to read the machine," he drawls, clearly disinterested.

Speaking in full, calm sentences and having an oxygen saturation of 70 percent are mutually exclusive events, paramedics know. Immediately, Alex identifies this call's headline: in her words, "the diff breather that wasn't."

Alex skims the man's medical files as she waits for the heart monitor to work. After a few minutes, the paramedics get a result. His oxygen saturation is 100 percent.

Alex places her stethoscope on his chest and hears a crackle in his lungs. Fluid buildup, she notes. Dialysis would help with that.

"Are your ankles swollen?" she asks. She gently peels the covers off his legs and laughs when she sees his feet bundled up in several layers of wool socks.

"You're adorable, you know that?" she says. He doesn't respond.

By now, Alex has identified the man's symptoms and his likely diagnosis: congestive heart failure, a common condition among the elderly.

The nurse wants him to go to the hospital, so for liability reasons, the

EMS staff have to take him there, even though he will miss his dialysis appointment that afternoon. He insists that the crew pack his laptop, his glasses, two cell phone chargers, and two phones in a pillowcase to take with him.

"Ready to fly, baby?" Alex smiles at the man as the team picks up the corners of the sheets to lift him and his many socks into the stretcher.

Alex sings, "I believe I can fly."



IN 2017, THE PARAMEDICS and EMTs of Empress Ambulance Services responded to about 39,000 911 calls in Yonkers, population 200,000. Paramedics told me stories about some of their recent emergency calls: a man's leg is broken in three places, and the train has sliced his waist; they tape his intestines and organs onto his body before moving him. A woman sobs on a bed because her husband is leaving her, an entire handle of vodka lying empty on the ground, her toddler nephew scootering around the first responders; they load her into an ambulance and head to the hospital's psychiatric ward.

Other calls, though, are more like the diff breather: they don't qualify as emergencies. Though EMS is built to deal with rare, unexpected medical crises, much of the staff's time is spent responding to non-urgent calls. For paramedics like Alex, one of the most frustrating and prevalent patterns is the high volume of non-emergency calls that the 911 dispatch receives daily.

"Everyone thinks what burns you out is the tragic shit: the shootings, the stabbings, the kids," said Mike Ceriani, a paramedic supervisor and Alex's coworker. "What burns you out are the people that you constantly pick up."

Empress employees are familiar with Yonkers' most common 911-call subjects and their pickup addresses. "Frequent flyers"—a subset of residents who are repeatedly picked up for non-crisis situations—often come from Chicken Island and "Ground Zero," the neighborhood with the oldest buildings in Yonkers, Alex told me.

Between jobs, in the supply room at Empress's base, a group of EMTs and paramedics recounted to me various frivolous 911 calls they'd recently received. Ailments included: caller had a cup of coffee at 2 a.m. and couldn't sleep; ate too many hotdogs; couldn't sleep because the sirens of passing EMS vehicles were too loud (she had work the next day, so would they please turn it down?); had a cuticle that hurt when touched but didn't want to pull it out because it would bleed; had a cold.

An internal study by Medstar, a large non-profit healthcare organization that handles medical emergencies, showed that 36.6 percent of their 911 calls in 2015 were non-emergencies, like "the diff breather that wasn't." Some Empress paramedics and EMTs estimate that non-emergencies make up closer to 40 percent of calls.

Paramedics are overqualified to be spending their days answering non-urgent calls. Alex is trained to administer over 20 different medications, ranging from narcotics to analgesics to paralytics, and she knows how each drug will interact with a patient's other medications and pre-existing conditions. While hospital anesthesiologists are taught never to intubate patients in anything less than the best lighting conditions on an operating table, Alex knows just how to angle a breathing tube between the "V" of an unconscious patient's vocal cords, anywhere, anytime. A paramedic's job is to extend emergency room care into the community, wherever it is needed, and Alex is prepared to do so.

But dispatchers are obligated to send out a team, no matter the apparent degree of urgency. The "prudent layperson" standard, a law in New York and 46 other states, requires that insurance coverage be based on patients' perceived symptoms, not their final diagnosis. Because health literacy tends to be low in Yonkers (and in the U.S.), Alex tells me, the reality of a self-report like "I have a cold" could be anything from a common cold

"Everyone thinks what burns you out is the tragic shit: the shootings, the stabbings, the kids.

What burns you out are the people that you constantly pick up."

to life-threatening pneumonia. In paramedic terms, all calls are either "bullshit" or "Oh, shit!" and deciphering between the two before arriving at the scene can be nearly impossible. In the fly car, paramedics sometimes play their own game of odds, calculating the probability of a call being legitimate based on the caller's address and description of the situation.

In November, 911 patient transports were projected to increase by 2,415 transports between 2014 and 2017. The upward creep is bigger than Yonkers. In the past several decades, emergency personnel across the country have seen a rise in non-emergency 911 calls in urban centers, news reports say. Studies have not been able to pinpoint a singular reason for the uptick. Several factors contribute: an aging population means more elderly health problems; population growth means more health problems across the board.

In an attempt to meet rising demand, Empress is growing. Today, the private ambulance company is contracted by various municipalities and hospitals of Westchester County, New York to provide emergency medical services. Since Transcare, another local private ambulance company, declared bankruptcy in 2016, Empress has hired more than 200 new employees. On certain days, the 50 or so vehicles they put on the road still aren't enough to handle the workload. More patients taken to the hospital means overcrowded hospitals. Doctors are busier, so paramedics and EMTs wait longer to give physicians their reports and have less time to respond to other calls—with potentially fatal consequences for needy patients.



ON ANOTHER FRIDAY afternoon in the fall of 2017, the emergency room at Saint Joseph's hospital is overflowing. By the circulation desk, three patients in stretchers wait to see a doctor. EMTs, paramedics, and police, who sometimes accompany drug overdose patients to the hospital, clog the narrow passageway. In curtained cubicles, patients lie in their beds and family members murmur. The doctors never stop moving between patients, like a game of human Ping-Pong.

Alex and I enter through the ambulance bay, bringing a particularly bad overdose patient to the hospital. The paramedics have injected him with 4.5 milligrams of Narcan, a drug administered to counteract the effects of opioid overdoses, and they have inflated his lungs with a manual resuscitator. Several minutes later, in the emergency room, the paramedics' interventions finally start working. The man sits up and looks around around the room with wide eyes.

Behind him, a nurse talks to a patient at the end of the line of stretchers. It's not obvious why he's here. Apparently, he called the ambulance because he said he had an asthma attack. He chats cheerily with the EMS workers around him. On his right wrist, he wears a hospital wristband from three hours ago. This is his second visit of the day.

"Stay until you're discharged next time. I hate to see you keep coming and going," a nurse tells him.

According to the paramedic that brought him in, this man is part of a population of homeless people who call 911 for a hot meal and a bed. When a paramedic asked him why he didn't just walk the six minutes to the emergency room, he tells the paramedic that "ambulances are the fastest mode of transportation."

In paramedic terms, all calls are either

“bullshit”

or

“Oh, shit!”

There's a cohort of "frequent flyers" who are each picked up three to six times a day, Alex said. "We know them by name, they know us." Repeat callers make up a significant portion of the 36.6 percent of 911 calls that are non-emergencies, though there is no official data on their impact. Often, it's because these individuals don't know where else to go for healthcare and don't have the wherewithal to follow doctors' advice for next time.

"There's a large part of the population that doesn't have primary care, even though there's been a big push for expanded healthcare and expanded Medicaid," said Hanan Cohen, a paramedic and Empress's director of business development. "They use the ER, which is not what they're meant for. So there's a lot of folks that dial 911 on a regular basis because that's the only way they know to access healthcare."

Neither the hospitals nor Empress benefit from non-urgent 911 calls. The financial risk of taking on 911 is why many ambulance companies do patient transports only, Cohen explained. In cities where the call volume isn't high enough to offset the costs of frivolous calls, the local government often hands out stipends to volunteer or nonprofit EMS services. Because of equipment, maintenance, and staffing costs, a basic life support ambulance costs around 400 dollars a trip, and an advanced life support ambulance costs around 900 dollars.

"In 911, our risk is, when someone calls 911, we're going to take care of them," Cohen said. "You don't ask for insurance in advance. The phone rings, you ask the screening questions, and you send the appropriate resource. At the end of that, you hope that folks have a respectable enough payment method to cover some profit."

Nationwide, approximately 35 percent of emergency-room patients are insured by Medicaid or Children's Health Insurance Program. About 14 percent have no insurance. Empress gives away over 2 million dollars in free healthcare services to uninsured and underinsured members of the community every year.

"It's who we are, it's what we've done. And we've been doing it for 30-some years. Doing just non-emergency transportation—that's a transportation service," Cohen said. "This is an emergency medical service."

But often, EMS transports arrive at the hospital and receive care, absent an emergency.



FLY CAR LIGHTS FLARING, sirens whooping, Mike Ceriani barrels down the hilly streets of southern Yonkers, slowing at busy intersections. ("I don't know where the best place to stop is, but directly in front of me is not it," he mutters.) As he swerves around oblivious pedestrians, I hold onto the grab handle above the passenger side window—the "Oh Shit" bar, in Mike's words.

For a 31-year-old, Mike is surprisingly old-school. While most paramedics and EMTs use phone apps for directions, Mike has proudly stuck his GPS on his windshield. We listen to the Trans-Siberian Orchestra through an auxiliary cord plugged into his sixth generation iPod Classic.

Mike has been a paramedic for two and a half years. He graduated paramedic school with Alex, who occasionally refers to him as Penguin because of his baldness and his pointy nose. In his many years in EMS, including time as an EMT, he's seen his share of overdoses, car accidents, and three-week-old corpses.

Mike and another ambulance team are on their way to treat a diabetic. Lights still spinning, we park in the curved driveway in front of an apartment building. We meet the other two paramedics, Joey and Brian, by the entrance and enter together. They cram a yellow-framed stretcher into the elevator.

When we reach the apartment on the 16th floor, the patient's daughter anxiously ushers us in.

We find the man in his bedroom. He looks like he's in his 50s or 60s. He hugs a navy blue pillow on a daybed and wears only underwear. Socks, shirts, and plastic wrappers are strewn on the white tile floor, though his collection of flat caps is hung neatly on a rack across his closet door.

He has been acting strangely all morning, his daughter tells us. She can't figure out how to use his finger-stick glucose meter.

As the paramedics ask him questions, he repeats their words, not quite understanding what they are saying.

When Joey pricks the man's finger, the meter shows that his blood sugar level is 42. A healthy person's target sugar levels are normally between 80 and 130.

They tie a rubber band near his right elbow, slide a small catheter into the underside of his elbow, and give him dextrose. Joey holds the bag over

"**There's a lot of folks** that dial 911 on a regular basis because that's the only way they know to access healthcare."

his head, and the tube runs from the bag into his veins. He becomes more cogent after a few minutes. The paramedics try again with the questions.

"When was the last time you took your insulin?"

"Yesterday."

His insulin is effective for 24 hours, so that wasn't the problem.

"When was the last time you ate?"

The man thinks for a minute.

"... yesterday."

Calls like these, from patients with chronic illnesses, are often preventable. Ideally, the diabetic would have known to eat after taking his insulin, and he and his daughter would have known how to use the finger-prick meter. They would have known that diabetes is caused by an inability to produce insulin, an enzyme that digests sugar in the blood so that the body can use it. They would have known that taking insulin and not eating meant that he was digesting more sugar than he had, which was what caused his hypoglycemia symptoms. A basic understanding of how diabetes works and how to manage it could have saved the patient a hospital bill and a trip to the emergency room.

"Folks get taken on a stretcher to the hospital, and just because they may not be well versed or very well educated, healthcare can be very confusing," Cohen, business director of Empress, explained. "Discharge orders and follow up instructions and community resources can all be just a puzzle—a jigsaw puzzle to people. So there's a lot of people providing post-acute care, but there's a whole lot of folks that just fall through all the social nets or the provisions of care."

Emergency rooms are designed to handle acute and trauma care. While doctors can tame flare-ups of chronic illnesses, long-term health problems require long-term solutions.

But lifestyle changes can be difficult. If patients return home to the same conditions and mindsets that caused the flare-up, they return to old habits, Alex told me. They make the same mistakes that brought them to the emergency room, and the cycle repeats.

In reality, Alex said, with the assistance of medical technology and pharmaceuticals, many chronic illnesses are manageable at home. Diabetes: eat regularly, take insulin regularly, know how to use a finger-stick glucose meter. Chronic obstructive pulmonary disease: don't smoke. Congestive heart failure: eat less salt, limit fluid intake, take your medicine.

Still, many patients don't know

how to manage their diseases. When symptoms flare up, EMS staff, rather than physicians, are the ones who hear about it first.



THOUGH EMS STAFF do their work at one of the most critical points in a patient's recovery, they are some of the most underappreciated members of the medical community. They operate away from expensive medical equipment and sterile environments but rarely receive the same recognition as physicians and nurses.

"EMS has become the safety net for healthcare," Cohen said. "So it's, 'Dial 911 for police, fire, or urgent healthcare,' and that's okay."

Unlike medical professionals treating patients in hospitals, EMS staff encounter their patients in context. They see the tangle of socioeconomic and mental health factors behind non-emergency calls. In 2017, Empress began its first foray into community paramedicine, a new program spearheaded by Cohen and Alex. The initiative will allow paramedics to schedule at-home follow-ups with discharged patients so they can teach patients and families about their conditions and how to manage them. Eventually, Cohen and Alex want patients to seek medical care that's appropriate for their ailments at urgent care centers and doctors' offices.

Community paramedicine will be 25 percent clinical work and 75 percent social work, Alex tells me, because the core of it is "that fish saying": give a man a fish, and you feed him for a day; teach a man to fish, and you feed him for a lifetime. Through community paramedicine, the Empress paramedics will be able to keep an eye on consenting at-risk patients and help them adjust their lives to suit their conditions.

Still, frivolous calls are part of the routine. It's easy to get frustrated, but Alex's personal philosophy helps her stay positive: the 15 to 20 minutes that the EMS staff are on the scene, she believes, is a small window to make a real impact on people's lives.

To Alex, EMS is about more than life and death. It's about respect and empathy. It's telling post-accident drivers that she "used to carry unicorn Band-Aids just for guys your size" until they smile shakily. It's talking to the nervous son wearing a Black Sabbath t-shirt about Ozzy Osbourne as they move his bedridden father into the ambulance, or laughing with the 92-year-old Ecuadorian grandmother with pneumonia, despite the language barrier. It's treating every 911 call with the seriousness of a life-threatening situation, no matter how trivial the caller's complaint might seem from the outside, because, as Alex often says, "perception is reality." She believes that's how each 911 call should be handled, no matter which side of the 36.6 percent it falls.

"I'm not trying to change the world," she tells me, "but you gotta have a pay it forward mindset."

"I Met When I Was Hi

AN INTERVIEW WITH

BY **AKHIL RAJAN**

Her

n She

PATTI SOLIS DOYLE

illary”

PATTI SOLIS DOYLE SERVED AS AN AIDE to Hillary Clinton LAW ’73 in 1992 and during the presidential campaign of Bill Clinton LAW ’73. She later managed Hillary Clinton’s 2000 and 2006 Senate campaigns and part of Clinton’s 2008 presidential campaign. Akhil Rajan of *The Politic* spoke with Solis Doyle about her experience working closely with the former first lady, senator, secretary of state, and presidential candidate.

"SHE WAS ALWAYS HILLARY TO ME"

YOU'VE WORKED A LOT OF YOUR CAREER, OVER 20 YEARS, WITH HILLARY CLINTON, AND THAT STARTED BEFORE SHE WAS EVEN FIRST LADY. I WANT YOU TO TALK A LITTLE BIT ABOUT THE MOMENT WHEN YOU REALIZED THAT SHE WAS MORE THAN JUST FIRST LADY OR A CAMPAIGNER BUT WAS THE CANDIDATE HERSELF. WHEN DID THAT TRANSITION HAPPEN IN YOUR MIND?

I started working for her in September of 1991. I took the job to work on Bill Clinton's presidential campaign.

The day I landed [in Arkansas], the campaign manager basically said, "Change of plans. So sorry, Bill Clinton's wife has been complaining that she doesn't have any staff people. I just assigned you to her. Go meet her."

I was very bummed. I didn't want to work for the wife. I wanted to get some real campaign experience under my belt. But I couldn't say no, so I went. And she shows up.

She's a partner in a law firm. She's beautiful. She basically says, "Hi, I'm Hillary, what am I doing next week?"

I said, "I have no idea. I literally just landed."

She's like, "OK, great. But here's the deal. I need to be home for my daughter, Chelsea. I need to be home on these days; I need to be home on the weekends. I can't be gone the same nights that my husband's gone. That's the parameter for me."

I was like, OK, so this is clearly an accomplished woman, but her priority is her child. And that really spoke to me. So that was one pivotal moment.

The second pivotal moment was...[when] we were going to raise money in Texas and California. And I heard her give the stump speech for the first time for her husband. The woman spoke without any notes in front of her, without any prepared draft that she had reviewed earlier. She spoke not only in complete sentences, but in complete paragraphs. It was as if she were dictating an already written speech.

I was blown away because she had this passion, this eloquence. And I said to myself that day, "This person should be running for president."

She was always Hillary to me. She was never First Lady Hillary Clinton, she was never Senator Clinton. She was never Madam Secretary. She was always Hillary to me because I met her when she was Hillary.

"A PERSON, NOT A FIGUREHEAD"

When she ran for Senate in 2000 in New York—a historic race because never had a sitting first lady ever run for public office—we had to hire a whole new cadre of people. I didn't know New York politics the way I needed to know New York politics in order to run a race there. So we had to hire a bunch of New York-centric consultants.

They all looked at her like she was some sort of fragile china doll, like, "How do we talk to her? She's the first lady of the United States of America. We need to be deferential."

She hated it with every fiber of her being because she felt like people weren't being honest with her...My first big job was to transition this new staff, to get them to treat her like a person, not a figurehead. And that was really challenging.

Her own staff was intimidated by her. [...] Throughout 2000, 2008, and even 2016, [that] was one of the obstacles that she faced—not just with future staff people, but with real voters. They saw her as this figure. They didn't see her as a real person. I consider myself very lucky because I knew her before she was the icon. I knew her when she was the person.

SO HOW DID YOU BREAK PAST THAT AS A CAMPAIGN OPERATIVE AND THEN AS THE MANAGER OF HER IMMEDIATE STAFF? HOW DID YOU GET PEOPLE TO SEE HER AS MORE OF A HUMAN BEING?

I had her get drunk with them. *[Both laugh.]* I did, I'm not kidding. So we would have meetings, and I'm like, "Hey, let's break some wine out," or, "Hey, let's order some Chinese." [...] I tried to put her in situations that were comfortable and revealing...and after time, that worked. It was a much harder situation with the electorate.

[It] was my idea for her to spend the night in people's homes rather than in hotels when she was traveling in upstate New York. That was a real groundbreaking move because first of all, the voters were like, "Oh my God, the first lady of the United States is staying in my house!" So they went through all these hoops to get the finest food, use their finest china. And [Hillary] was like, "No, you know, let's get a burger." She would clean her own plate and wash the dishes, and she would strip her bed in the morning. She was a real person. And she did that at least 20 times.

That reverberated across the state. The host family would then tell their neighbors, and they would tell everybody who lived on the block, and those people would tell the people they worked with. It was a really great way to sort of break down the barrier.

Obviously, that was a much harder thing to do on a national level in the '08 campaign. But it worked in New York.

"I DIDN'T WANT TO JUST DO THE RIGHT THING"

ONE OF THE MOMENTS THAT'S REALLY RESURFACED, ESPECIALLY TODAY, IN LIGHT OF RECENT NATIONAL CONVERSATIONS ABOUT #METOO, WAS THE HANDLING OF AN AIDE WHO WAS ACCUSED OF SEXUAL MISCONDUCT THAT YOU WANTED FIRED. IN A NORMAL ELECTION...DO YOU BELIEVE A DECISION LIKE THAT BY A CANDIDATE SHOULD BE DISQUALIFYING?

Today?

YES.

Yes, I do. Back then, obviously, it was 10 years ago, and it was a different time. But it wasn't lost on me that I was the first Hispanic woman campaign manager of a presidential campaign. It wasn't lost on me that I didn't want to just do the right thing. I wanted to be better than any other campaign manager had ever been.

When confronted with this issue, I wanted to send a signal to the rest of the staff that this kind of behavior was not okay. And I wanted to send a signal to the rest of the staff that if anything like this happens to you, of course you can come and talk to me about it or talk to your boss about it, and we're going to do something. So when she overruled me...I don't think I've ever been as disappointed and as angry with her. But this is also the same woman who allowed me to bring my three-month-old baby to the White House because she knew I was struggling with balancing my motherhood with my career. This is the woman who, for 30 years, doggedly advocated for equal rights, equal pay, women's health. To me, this one horribly bad call wasn't enough to negate a 30-year career in advocating for women.

Sharing the Burden

Ministries Offer an Alternative to Traditional Health Insurance

BY **JULIANNA LAI**

"OVER A FOUR YEAR PERIOD, we paid out $112,000 toward medical expenses," wrote 56-year-old Mary Smith, whose real name will not be used for the sake of anonymity, in an email to *The Politic*. "We simply couldn't do it any longer, we were going broke!"

Although generally healthy and free of chronic illnesses, Smith and her family hit their out-of-pocket maximum every year between 2012 and 2015 solely due to unexpected expenses. On one occasion, Smith tore her knee on a ski trip. The next year, her daughter contracted acute pancreatitis. As the bills racked up, Smith's employer coverage under Anthem Blue Cross, which cost 1,700 dollars per month and had a 13,000-dollar deductible, became unaffordable.

The Smiths are an upper middle-class family in the suburbs of Denver living on a combined annual income of 150,000 dollars, though they consider themselves "slightly poor," according to Mary, who is one of fewer than 25 employees at the local business where she works. She and her husband, a small business owner, support two adult children living at home—affordable housing in the area is scarce—and they pay their daughter's college tuition. They have not taken a vacation in years and do not anticipate that they will have saved enough within the next ten years to be able to retire.

In 2017, the Smiths feverishly researched insurance alternatives, but their age and income bracket limited their options. In their desperation, they came across a healthcare sharing plan offered by Medi-Share, a faith-based nonprofit that distributes healthcare costs among its members. Through the ministry, Smith could choose the monthly premium that suited her needs and budget. Four hundred and sixteen dollars a month with an annual 5,000-dollar deductible was a welcome relief.

GALATIANS 6:2, quoted on the ministry Altrua HealthShare's website, reads, "Carry each other's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."

In the U.S., opinion is divided over whether the free market or the government should control healthcare costs. Conventional wisdom in a capitalist economy holds that the government tends to be less efficient than the private sector, and its services more expensive. But Americans face higher costs than Canadians, Swedes, the French, whose governments fund public healthcare.

"We simply couldn't do it any longer, we were going broke!"

The Smiths joined over a million other Americans who have abandoned insurance plans in favor of healthcare sharing ministries. When *The Washington Post* reported on healthcare sharing ministries in 2005, they were still referred to as "church plans" in the insurance industry, and only an estimated 120,000 Americans—mostly in the South—claimed membership in fewer than a dozen nonprofit faith-based healthcare sharing organizations. Now, though official statistics do not exist, nonprofit groups that offer ministry plans report that over 1.1 million Americans depend on each other to pay their medical bills.

In the late 1980s, healthcare sharing ministries began operating under a simple premise: people who share similar religious beliefs could also share each other's medical expenses.

Some of the more traditionalist ministries like Samaritan Ministries International require written confirmation from a priest or pastor that a new applicant regularly attends church services. At Florida-based Christian Care Ministry, applicants must sign a statement of faith that commits ministry members to Christian lifestyles. Members are asked to avoid "food, behaviors or habits that produce sickness or disease," like smoking and drinking.

In its Statement of Standards, Altrua HealthShare says that its members believe that "marriage is a bond between a man and a woman," that "sexual relations outside the bond of marriage are morally wrong," and that "abortion is wrong except

in a life-threatening situation to the mother." Members should not expect the ministries to cover expenses associated with IUDs or pregnancies out of wedlock.

But in general, with ministry membership exploding nationwide, members are bound together less by faith and more by their practical need for affordable healthcare. A particularly attractive aspect of healthcare sharing is that members are exempt from Obamacare's individual mandate tax penalties. Under the Affordable Care Act, ministries must qualify as nonprofit organizations and must have existed since December 31, 1999 in order for their members to receive tax benefits. Ministries that do not meet these qualifications can instead offer to pay the tax penalties incurred by members.

Over 1.1 million Americans depend on each other to pay their medical bills.

Fifty-four-year-old life insurance agent Patrick Cloutier is a practicing Catholic subscribed to Liberty HealthShare's Mennonite "Complete" plan. He does not recall needing to affirm his religion when he first signed up for ministry coverage.

"Religion was a non-factor for me," Cloutier said in an interview with *The Politic*. "The big factor for me was the economics. I was going from paying 1,900 dollars a month down to paying 299 a month. I could pick my own doctors, and the Liberty HealthShare Complete is the only one of these plans that offers one million per incident."

Similarly, faith had little to do with 64-year-old Maury Radin's decision to purchase a ministry plan through Aliera Healthcare. While he was required to sign a contract of shared beliefs, Radin said that the principles were "broad and universal" and could be applied across religious faiths and values. He and his wife—both healthy individuals—are just a year away from Medicare eligibility and found healthcare sharing out of frustration with insurance companies' soaring premiums. But had he been able to afford the rising costs, Radin said he would have stayed with insurance just to support Obamacare.

"I didn't [choose healthcare sharing] to avoid the individual mandate," Radin said. "I, frankly, am a big supporter of the Affordable Care Act and universal healthcare."

With insurance, the Radins were paying 1,800 dollars per month for healthcare. Now, they spend 860 dollars per month.

"THE MEANS BY WHICH [ministries] pay medical bills varies," *POLITICO* healthcare reporter Paul Demko said in an interview with *The Politic*. "In most instances, people send in a monthly fee—what you would call a premium in medical insurance parlance, but they don't use that term. The ministry collects those dollars, and then once people have medical bills that they need covered, they will allocate money."

Under at least one plan offered by the Florida-based nonprofit Medi-Share, Demko said, ministry members send checks directly to other participants.

The healthcare sharing ministries avoid using industry jargon because, fundamentally, they are not insurance agencies and do not calculate risk. Wiley Long, president of HSA for America—an online health insurance agency that brokers hundreds of plans from major healthcare sharing organizations like Aliera and Altrua as well as insurance companies—said that the ministries have to be upfront about the drawbacks of healthcare sharing in order to avoid running into lawsuits.

Customers should make no mistake: most healthcare sharing ministries do not offer protection for pre-existing conditions or cancer. Nor do they cover emergency room expenses or prescription medication. There is no guarantee they will cover medical bills in full.

While they do have many features in common with insurance companies, including direct negotiations with healthcare providers over reimbursement rates, Demko said some nonprofit co-op plans had been terminated by states for failing to price

"I was going from paying 1,900 dollars a month down to paying 299 a month."

"If I have a stroke or for the grace of God I get cancer tomorrow, those will eat up 125,000 dollars in no time. That's a really big risk."

their products correctly. Should there be an unexpected rush of particularly expensive patients, there is no way for a ministry to guarantee that it will have enough money on hand to pay for all—or any—of the claims it receives.

Cloutier explained that the cap on benefits for most ministry plans is around 125,000 dollars per incident. "If I have a stroke or for the grace of God I get cancer tomorrow, those will eat up 125,000 dollars in no time. That's a really big risk."

Typically, insurance is heavily regulated, particularly by state insurance commissioners. But in the case of healthcare sharing ministries, there is no state or federal oversight.

In states like Kentucky, Maryland, and Wisconsin, legislators have passed specific regulatory exemptions for ministry plans as long as they make it clear that they are not insurance. But commissioners are concerned that consumers may not fully understand the limits of healthcare sharing coverage. According to the Center on Health Insurance Reform, by 2013, 21 states had passed laws allowing ministries to escape regulation because they were considered faith-based alternatives. As ministries relax the religious requirements of their mission, legislators may need to reexamine the immunity they have given the healthcare sharing industry.

HEALTHCARE SHARING ministries have existed largely under the radar of both Democrats and Republicans, attracting more consumers than expected when Obamacare was instituted in 2010. While it is difficult to unpack their rationale eight years later, Demko said that legislators crafting the Affordable Care Act apparently exempted the ministry plans from the individual mandate penalty in an effort to placate Christian conservatives.

"I don't think anybody foresaw at that time that they would grow more than eight fold over the ensuing eight years," Demko said. "It was really an afterthought; it got no attention at the time as a provision in the Senate bill...Because of the very tortured way in which the ACA was passed, the Senate version of the bill ended up being the bill that was enacted."

Demko added that the House version had not included the provision exempting healthcare sharing plans. Had the bill gone to a conference committee, as is typically the case when two different versions of a bill are presented, there was "no way on Earth" the exemption would have survived, a former Senate staffer told him.

Because ministry members are expected to be relatively healthy, the proliferation of healthcare sharing plans has significant consequences for Obamacare's exchange market, exacerbating the challenge it faced from the outset: attracting enough young, healthy people to create balanced risk pools and avoid high premiums.

Even now, with more than one million members relying on the ministries for coverage, Demko has not heard of any movement from Democrats or Republicans to limit the plans' proliferation. This March, Representative Mike Kelly (R-PA) introduced a bipartisan bill that encourages ministry enrollees to pay for their plans with health savings accounts.

In many ways, healthcare sharing suits the Republican predilection for giving Americans a variety of coverage options in the insurance marketplace. The current administration has committed itself to loosening the rules around selling cheaper, skinnier insurance plans that do not adhere to the coverage requirements of the Affordable Care Act.

But Americans are already taking those sorts of risks with healthcare sharing. Opting for ministry plans is less about avoiding penalties and more about lowering overall costs. On average, Long's clients see their monthly medical expenses cut in half, even if they lack the protections of insurance. Having some coverage is better than having none, the reasoning goes, regardless of what's in the fine print.

"It seems every aspect of our healthcare system is broken, from the astronomical cost of insurance, medical services, prescription drugs [to] the need for charitable services," Smith wrote.

Cloutier said, "If your decisions are based on economics, which mine clearly were to a large extent, then that's going to remain the case into the future. The situation is the boss."

EYES ON THE REVOLUTION


PHOTOS BY **CHRISTINA FIGLUS**

BY **CHRISTINA FIGLUS**

A Personal Account of Ukraine's Euromaidan Movement

I WAS FIFTEEN when a revolution in Ukraine sent shockwaves across Europe. When violence broke out, in the winter of 2013-2014, many of my expatriate friends were forcibly evacuated to London or Paris, but I stayed. Though I'm a U.S. citizen, Ukraine is my home—I grew up and lived there for most of my life. I experienced the revolution firsthand. Ten months after the revolution ended, in December 2014, my mother would become the first foreign-born Minister of Finance.

During the revolution, I went to protests, I marched—and, most importantly, I never put down my camera.

IN THE FALL of 2013, Ukrainian President Viktor Yanukovych was set to sign the Ukraine-European Union Association Agreement, which would put Ukraine on a path toward merging its economic, judicial, and financial policies with those of the E.U. The agreement—which the majority of Ukrainians supported—had been under negotiation since before Yanukovych was president. But on November 21, 2013—eight days before the scheduled signing in Vilnius, Lithuania—Yanukovych said that he was considering forming stronger trade relations with Russia, instead of pursuing trade relations with the E.U.

That evening, in a Facebook post, Afghani-Ukrainian activist and journalist Mustafa Nayyem called on the Ukrainian people to gather in the center of Kyiv at Maidan Nezalezhnosti, or Independence Square, to demonstrate their support for the E.U. Association Agreement and protest the president's consideration of closer ties with Russia. At the time, few imagined that the demonstration at Maidan would attract more than a few thousand people. But by the end of the week, crowds of Ukrainians hundreds of thousands of people strong (estimates varied widely, ranging from 200,000 to 2,000,000) had joined the self-named Euromaidan movement in Kyiv.

Closer ties to the E.U. would distance Ukraine from Russia, which has historically attempted to exert control over its neighbor. Many pro-Euromaidan Ukrainians saw the E.U. as more democratic and less corrupt than Ukraine, and hoped that these values would transfer to their country.

On November 29, Yanukovych traveled to Vilnius and met with European leaders, but the day came and went without his signing the E.U. agreement. Instead, Yanukovych ordered Berkut special police units to disperse the protesters camping out on Maidan.



"DEMAND NO. 1: RESIGNATION OF PRESIDENT YANUKOVYCH"

UKRAINIAN PROFESSIONAL COSSACK





PRESIDENT YANUKOVYCH WITH A CLOWN NOSE

The Berkut units violently attacked the protesters, most of whom were university students, in the middle of the night, beating them with metal batons and dragging them away from the square. This violence was uncharacteristic for Ukraine—neither independence in 1991 nor the Orange Revolution in 2004 involved bloodshed, according to Serhii Plokii of Harvard's Ukrainian Research Institute in an interview with *National Geographic*.

Rather than frightening the protesters into submission, the violence encouraged more Ukrainians to join the Euromaidan cause. This time, protesters weren't just fighting for the E.U. Association Agreement; they were fighting for their civil rights. The movement retained its original name, though, and Euromaidan came to represent the desire for a Ukraine without corruption or abuse of power.

The violence perpetrated against the university students on the night of November 30 was the spark that ignited a roaring fire. Many Ukrainians had been disenchanted with their corrupt city and national governments, but now they were angry—they had had enough.

WITHIN A WEEK of the violence, protesters set up tents on Maidan and established a perimeter around their new camp, complete with kitchens, first-aid huts, and a multi-faith chapel. The mood was happy, even euphoric, as hundreds of thousands of people



marched for the civil rights of the Ukrainian people. People sang folk songs, hung Ukrainian flags, and danced around campfires in displays of patriotism. We were hopeful about Ukraine's future, even as barricades built out of park benches and pieces of the dismantled national Christmas tree, called the Yolka, reminded everyone why they stood on Maidan, protesting in below-freezing temperatures.

The diversity of participants in the rallies and marches was astounding. The protesters were as young as high school students, like me at the time, and as old as those who remembered World War II. Politically, some leaned left, others right. They were Jewish, Ukrainian Orthodox, Protestant, Greek Catholic, Roman Catholic, and Muslim; they were ethnically Russian, Polish, Ukrainian, Armenian, and Crimean Tatar. They were not all civil society organizers or political activists—they were ordinary people. They might not have spoken one language or shared one history, but they were united in support of a Ukraine for all citizens, regardless of ethnicity, religion, or language.

EARLY IN THE NEW year, on January 16, 2014, the Ukrainian Parliament voted to pass a series of anti-protest laws. These laws, later dubbed the Black Thursday Laws, criminalized the public display of national symbols, such as the flag and the crest; limited the right to assemble; and made the "slander" of public officials punishable by a yearlong term of "corrective labor." They also required mandatory registration of internet media and cell phones.

During the vote, Yanukovych's Party of Regions locked opposition members of Parliament out of the legislative chamber and voted on each bill with a brief show of hands.

A TENT THAT READS "DROHOBYCH," THE NAME OF A SMALL TOWN IN UKRAINE



Because of the voting method, the majority of Ukrainians were reluctant to give credence to the new laws. They continued to protest, despite the threats of jail terms and arbitrary arrest. Instead of trying to get around the laws, protesters made light of them. They blatantly disobeyed the prohibition against wearing construction helmets and face masks, donning anything they could find to break the law—including masquerade masks, funky hats, and even kitchen pots.

The sense of urgency in the movement grew as it took on a darker and more determined tone. No longer did young women sing folk songs and dance; instead, they milled around wearing red cross symbols, their jaws set, as if waiting for the inevitable confrontation between government forces and protesters. Euromaidan's self-defense league, a group of protesters who peacefully resisted violent police provocations, began wearing face masks to hide their identities from authorities. A fight was brewing.

On January 19, as I was leaving the ninth Sunday Meeting, a weekly mass protest, a commotion broke out on Hrushevskoho Street, about a block from Maidan. People were running and yelling, telling women and children to "go the other way."

Later that evening, clashes between riot police and protesters made the news. It was unclear who started the conflict, but the initial pushing and shoving had turned into a violent altercation, with Berkut police units shooting water cannons into the masses. A few days after the initial clashes, people began to show up at hospitals with gunshot wounds.

Four people died in the conflict. One fell off a roof when confronted by Berkut units (some speculate that he may have been pushed), two were shot, and one activist was abducted from the hospital and later found dead.

Suddenly, the danger became much more real to me. Up to this point, it had seemed as if a compromise with the Yanukovych govern-

ment was still possible.

But now that four people had lost their lives, the protesters would accept nothing short of Yanukovych's resignation.

ON FEBRUARY 18, 2014, toward the end of the school day, an email notified my classmates and me that all extracurriculars had been canceled and that we had to leave immediately. Everyone around me felt that something was not right. Our school had been shut down only once before, on collective security recommendations from the U.S., French, and British embassies.

I did not know how bad things were until I got home and found out that there would be no school until further notice. Not long after, some friends from the city arrived at my house, about half an hour outside the city limits, and planned to stay until further notice. Every live stream from downtown Kyiv showed the city in flames that evening. The buildings and landscape I knew so well had disappeared behind walls of smoke. Protesters were burning tires to block the sightlines of snipers and armored vehicles.

After four days of fighting, more than one hundred protesters were killed, mostly by sniper bullets to the head, throat, or chest. Whoever had fired the bullets was shooting to kill. Protesters sang the national anthem and armed themselves with wooden shields and Molotov cocktails to fight against security forces' armored cars and bullets. On television and live streams, the country watched.



MAN WITH A BOOK OF PSALMS

ON THE MORNING of February 22, 2014, after 94 days of protest, Ukrainians woke to find that the fight was over. Yanukovych had fled to Russia with his cabinet and many of his political associates. The Ukrainian parliament formally impeached him later that day. Tens of thousands of Ukrainians stormed Yanukovych's presidential compound, the inside of which had never been seen by the public. They found a small zoo, a golf course, a classic car collection, and artwork that the president had probably stolen from state museums, according to *The Washington Post*.

Later in the year, Acting Prosecutor General Oleh Makhnitsky accused Yanukovych of running a criminal syndicate during his time as president. According to *Reuters*, Yanukovych and his allies had stolen an estimated 350 million dollars from the state, costing Ukraine 100 billion dollars, more than



SECURITY FORCES



half of its economic output in 2013.

For many, the end of the revolution brought a sense of relief. It was as if an entire nation had held its breath for 94 days and now was exhaling for the first time. But the dominant feeling was shock. After over a half century of relative peace in Ukraine, there were now, suddenly, over one hundred dead and thousands more wounded.

Most Ukrainians did not lose friends or family in the conflict, but the pain still felt personal and traumatic. All Ukrainians knew it could have been their sons, brothers, husbands, or fathers who were now heralded as members of "Heaven's Hundred," the name given to the people killed.

I am sure few Ukrainian citizens will forget watching the funerals. Tens of thousands of us attended the services, which were held on Maidan. In one particularly memorable moment, a widow described her late husband, who was killed in the protests. He had left his hometown for Kyiv days before he became a father. He did not want his daughter to grow up in a country without freedom or civil rights.



"DO NOT TOUCH, PRESERVED FOR INVESTIGATION"



What does it mean to experience collective trauma? How can something be so personal and still be shared by millions of people? Even now, at annual memorials, when the folk song played at the funerals comes on, it is hard to find a Ukrainian who does not shed tears. For those who were part of Euromaidan, this song triggers pain from loss we haven't yet accepted.

ON FEBRUARY 27, 2014, armed men in unmarked military uniforms seized government buildings in Crimea and raised Russian flags. Still reeling in the revolution's aftermath, Ukrainian citizens watched in horror as Russia annexed Crimea the next month. The war in the Donbass region of eastern Ukraine began soon after, when Russian tanks crossed the border. This war is still active today and has claimed the lives of over ten thousand soldiers and civilians. Another one and a half million have been displaced.

The E.U. Association Agreement, which was the impetus for the revolution, was eventually signed in two parts, the first on March 21, 2014 and the second on June 27. The agreement took effect on September 1, 2017.

Before the Euromaidan movement, I led a normal life as a teenager in high school. But over the course of the revolution, I felt that my childhood ended. I had to face the revolution and its aftermath as an adult. To this day, taking part in the revolution, no matter how small a role I might have played, is the most powerful thing I have done.

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Caring at Careways: Closing New Haven's Women's Shelters

BY **BERENICE VALENCIA FERNÁNDEZ**

Over the last few years, New Haven shelters have experienced increased difficulty finding funding. Government spending has been directed towards affordable housing projects rather than homeless shelters, resulting in shelter closures. Berenice Valencia Fernández discusses the closure of New Reach's Careways shelter for single women with children.

Your Way Contraception: The Politics of Plan B Vending Machines

BY **EMILY XU**

Imagine being able to purchase emergency contraception, condoms, UTI medication, and allergy medication all from the convenience of a dorm vending machine. Currently, the two most common places to buy emergency contraception are University health centers and local pharmacies. However, the health centers are often closed on the weekends and local pharmacies are often out of stock. Emily Xu '21 reports on efforts to install a vending machine on Yale's campus.

Battlegrounds for Equality: Representing History at Yale's Art Galleries

BY **DAVID EDIMO**

1968 was a year of turmoil. As Martin Luther King Jr. was shot and draft deferments were rescinded, marginalized and young artists fought back in order to shape public perception. They struggled against conservative art museums and hostile audiences. David Edimo '21 discusses how fifty years later, several programs at Yale are reflecting on the role that protest art and physical material played in advancing and recording the social movements of the day.

United Against Benetton: Argentina's Mapuche Fight Against the Clothing Corporation

BY **LENA GALLAGER**

United Colors of Benetton is the largest landholder in Argentina, owning about 2.2 million acres of land, about the size of Puerto Rico. Much of the popular clothing company's landholdings are undeveloped, with some allocated for wool production, mining, and logging. However, there is one large problem: this land has historically been inhabited by the Mapuche, one of Argentina's prominent ethnic groups. Lena Gallager '21 reports on the Mapuche's struggle to keep their homeland.

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